brought the biggest stars of the day to Cuba," and their children could study the dance at the Escuela Pro Arte Musical in Havana.[33] Meanwhile African-based dance forms like the *rumba* flourished among the popular classes, but were disdained and persecuted by polite society.

The revolutionary government set about to democratize access to formerly "high" culture, and to elevate and promote Cuban cultural forms formerly viewed as "low." The Conjunto Folklórico Nacional (National Folkloric Group) was founded in 1962 to "contribute to the rescue and recovery of our dance and musical roots."[34] As ethnomusicologist Yvonne Daniel explains, "Cuba's revolution in 1959 served to distinguish and further separate differing African religious practices, as the new nation looked inward for its identity. During the early days of restructuring a new society, African religions were highlighted as proof of Cuba's Afro-Latin, rather than simply Hispanic, identity. While actual religious behavior was repressed within Cuba's early communist/atheistic ideology, cultural representations from its African religious history were promoted as such in educational and tourist settings."[35]

Reporter Ana Campoy interviewed Fernando Alonso, husband and professional partner of celebrated ballerina Alicia Alonso. Early in 1959, she recounts, the Revolution "knocked on the Alonsos' door … In walked Fidel Castro and one of his collaborators. Sitting on the edge of the bed, they talked with Fernando about world and local politics for hours, until Fidel said, 'I came here to talk about ballet.' 'I always have time to talk about ballet,' Fernando recalls saying. 'How much money do you need for the ballet company to start up again?' Fidel asked. 'I don't know, *Comandante*, 100,000 dollars,' answered Fernando. Fidel, Fernando says, gave them 200,000. 'The revolution was a beautiful thing in the beginning,' Fernando says."[36]

The National Ballet Company performed revolutionary ballets, and they performed them everywhere: "on makeshift platforms set in factories, in schools, and in countryside cane fields." Today, "ballet followers more resemble a sports crowd than the aristocratic elite who first brought the dance form to Cuba," Campoy explains. "Fans yell and